

Oct 22 - LinkedIn Learning: Preproduction

① Birth of an Idea

Ideation - which ideas are good & which can fit into a documentary

specifically
from outside
the topic↳ what ~~about~~ do you already know?

- start w/ connections, relationships, knowledge

↳ personal angle can be an entry point

↳ brings referrals & primary documents

↳ need to still have a critical eye

- where you aren't connected

↳ there is ~~about~~ perhaps a 2nd or 3rd degree connection to important figures

↳ building relationships through volunteering

or before approaching to film can help

- inspiration can come from other media, picking a story & expanding on a journalist's work

Developing your idea into framework

↳ your passion - keeps momentum

↳ who is the audience → appealing to universal human

↓
primary audience & ↑ truth↳ will you have access?

story, characters, locations, archival material, stock footage, personal photos/memorabilia

↳ will it be a good film?

needs a narrative arc; needs to be visual

* are there visual patterns/motifs?

↳ fundability: target audience, broader appeal; connection to social issues

Pitch for funders!
↳ research funders — how/does it fit into their niche
persuasive, punchy language
character — needs to show who it's about
summarize concepts & goals but not too detailed
takeaway, what should folks feel afterward
pls sell yourself — why you're a good choice, ^{can} include reel

Pitch happens mid-production, can include film
should be under 5 min, pre-written, delivered orally

Example structure:

Hook — funder's struggle

Story — main emotional beats / set pieces of film

Audience x Objective — who & why it appeals

Production details — I have contacts with X, have been cleared to do film X

Might have a Q&A, written pitch w/ more details

Proposal — things may change into production
— for fundraising etc

incl { Docu info: synopsis, BG, descrip, style, aud, goals
Logistics: crew, budget, fundraising, prod. sched.
plans for distrib, marketing

Logline — sentence ~~para~~, catchy to learn more

Synopsis

Background — about the topic & why it's important

Description — style, structure, voice, approach

Film elements & assets — content & style of interviews

B-roll, observational scenes,
archival materials, photos, graphics etc

Editing
style/structure

doesn't
necessarily
include
names/org
names

★ better to be specific & change than
not be specific

Treatment - not a summary

Think of [story beats → scenes → Acts] the structure

Other possible details: shooting plan & logistics, crew, budget, location info, equipment, fundraising, production/post-production schedule, distribution & marketing.

★ THIS IS A WORKING DOC

② PREPRODUCTION!

ASSETS: WRITTEN, VISUAL, PERSONAL RESEARCH SOURCES

WRITTEN - ~~W~~ DIGITAL & TRADITIONAL

↳ VITAL TO VET

VISUAL - ARTISTIC DOCUMENTS

How ARE OTHERS APPROACHING?

- CAN OFTEN BE USED AS VISUALS

PERSONAL - ATTEND TALKS, ~~RESEARCH~~ REACH OUT TO ~~PEOPLE FROM~~ SOURCES FROM RESEARCH, ALWAYS END DISCUSSION W/ ASK FOR REFERRAL

WHAT INFO TO CHASE, WHAT TO LEAVE

↳ PROVIDE NEW IDEAS, AVOID WHAT OTHERS HAVE COVERED

↳ ~~BE~~ Show multiple sides of the issue

ASSETS - INTERVIEW, B-ROLL, PHOTOS, OBSERVATIONAL FOOTAGE, maps/graphics/visual aids

voiceover narration, onscreen text, music & sound effects

★ ROUGHLY PLAN BEATS, CAPTURE ENOUGH TO BE FLEXIBLE

INTERVIEW PLAN - start w/ story plan

- identify ~~who~~ who will speak at each point, ~~the~~ focus interviews

- this makes ~~the~~ editing easier

For each interview - begin with the answers you want & work backwards to Qs

- structure - broad to narrow, basics to details, greater explanations, be strategic abt difficult Qs

★ EXPECT THINGS TO CHANGE IN PRODUCTION

- You can use "tell me about x"
- Prep interviewees w/ general topics, but not memorizable Qs

PRE-INTERVIEWS

- ↳ talk through main topics you want to discuss
- ↳ establish rapport, assess knowledge, save the goods!!
- ↳ Primary vs Secondary subjects oft have different prep levels

*Pre prod - getting team on board

- treatment - visual description - what the viewer will see
Active, present tense, specific (NOT EDITORIALIZED, SUMMARIZED)

- ↳ easiest if you've done research already
- ↳ from imagination. You are guessing!
- ↳ developing ~~visual~~ editing ideas, motifs

- Script

↳ one option: 2 column script

Left: visuals

Right: sound

~~Visual~~ film cuts,

sound effects, VO,

graphics/images

music

↳ Update after production - so you have pre-pro script
post-pro script

- Storyboard - documentarier ^{don't} ~~aren't~~ usually
have drawn storyboards. often instead use stock images
to represent visuals

YOU MIGHT
USE ANY or
ALL of THESE
ELEMENTS

Non-production materials i.e. archival etc

Public domain material - do research to ensure
images are actually public domain
- see creative commons

Stock footage libraries

↳ Royalty-free (can be versatile)

↳ Rights-Managed Licenses - ~~might~~ has restrictions

- commercial use → often staged

- Editorial use → often authentic

↳ Directly licensed from owners

Planning Production Assets

Interviews - go to their location or neutral location

B-roll - bridges jump cuts

- meant to go over interviews

* OBSERVATIONAL SCENES ARE SEPARATE

- special film types like slow-mo, time lapse

Actual Plan

#1 Interviews - hardest to schedule

↳ MANY INTERVIEWS IN SHORT TIME:

easiest in one location

↳ IF INTERVIEWEES HAVE TO TRAVEL, KEEP IT
CONVENIENT

↳ PREVIEW LOCATION, PLAN TO VARY BGS

↳ PLAN DOWNTIME BTW INTERVIEWS, SET TIME SLOTS

PRE-INTERVIEW DETAILS - cal invite, example qs,
thank you note
REMINDER EMAIL DAY BEFORE

#2 BROLL/OBSERVATIONAL SCENES

SHOT LIST - CATEGORIES, TYPES OF SHOTS

FOR OBS SCENES, NEED TO PLAN FOR EDIT - MANY DIFF
COMPOSITIONS & ANGLES
LONG TO CLOSE UP

* NEEDS MORE TIME

For 20min
Doc, 12 interviews
conducted